

gleaned from propaganda handouts of one kind or another or heard as rumors in the streets.

Remember the perennial tale of the leprous Chinese cook's thumb that turned up in a bowl of chow mein at the (usually local) chop suey parlor? That particular yarn was already hoary with age when I was a boy—yet it's still making the rounds, and it's still being given credence by the gullible. This, of course, is an extreme example, but businessmen frequently allow their judgment to be influenced by opinions and rumors which, in their own way, are no less factitious than this unappetizing fable. Many otherwise astute businessmen will buy or sell sizable blocks of stock merely because they "hear" that certain issues are

"due" to go up or down on the Stock Exchange. Nine times out of ten, they find that they've done the wrong thing because they listened to opinions or rumors rather than determine the facts for themselves.

A short time ago, a manufacturer I know spent nearly \$100,000 tooling up and buying the raw materials to produce a novelty item which, according to trade journal articles he'd read, was in great demand. Not until he was

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ready to go into production did he discover that half-a-dozen other firms were ahead of him and beginning to distribute the item. The market was saturated even before his salesmen could start selling his product. He was badly stuck. This could not have happened had he checked all the facts before leaping into a clearly stupid business situation.

There may be some substitute for hard facts and factual information, but if there is, I have no idea what it can be. It certainly isn't rumor or opinion that has been camouflaged as fact. In order to succeed in any "deal," project or endeavor, the businessman must assemble all the available pertinent hard facts and study and analyze them himself.

There's nothing wrong in asking the opinions of others and in taking them into consideration. The mistake lies in accepting and following other people's advice blindly, in accepting their opinions without first determining